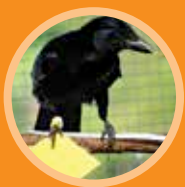




THIS IS TECHNOLOGY, CULTURE AND SCIENCE WITH A DIFFERENCE, AND THAT DIFFERENCE IS USUALLY ENOUGH TO MAKE MOST NORMAL PEOPLE GO "WTF?"

This month in ALT:

This month find out everything you should know about Bluetooth 5.1, explore the dinosaur family tree, know all the tech that resides in cruise ships and witness some of the strangest Google Earth sites.



The Millennial Raven

A droll and amusing poem by Ross Wolinsky that captures the feeling of living the high tech low life, a boring techno futuristic dystopia that we all inhabit. <https://dgit.in/millrav>

WHAT'S NEW

SMS is broken and fixing it is hard

Despite the availability of WhatsApp, iMessage, Messenger, Telegram and other IM clients, the good old SMS remains the most-used text messaging service in the world. This is because it is by default on every phone. However, the technology is decades old, and the whole system is broken. There are instances when messages are delivered months after they were sent. The text messages are not encrypted, and pass through multiple servers, of various services providers. Even sensitive information such as links for password resets, PIN codes, and two factor authentication codes are delivered via SMS, despite the communication channel being unencrypted. Some service providers may even outsource



the functionality to third parties. The next generation of SMS services, RCS (rich communication services) does not have encryption as well. RCS is being developed by the GSMA Association trade

body, with support from manufacturers such as Google and Samsung. While RCS could have incorporated encryption easily, the deliberate choice has been made not to. SMS is really old technology, used by everyone, and unfortunately, there does not seem to be an easy way to secure the service.

<https://dgit.in/smsbrk>

Criminals are using bluetooth scanners to burgle cars

Aspate of car break ins at Silicon Valley in the US shows a peculiar pattern. Some vehicles are broken into in parking lots, and even though there might be other valuables in the vehicle, the thieves take only electronic equipment such as laptops, phones and other gadgets. This has led those that were robbed to believe that the criminals are using bluetooth scanning apps to find electronics even when they are idling. The apps are designed

to help find lost equipment, but they show a lot of information such as the type of devices, the



other bluetooth devices that they may currently be paired with, and even an approximate distance to

a particular device. Researchers have previously dismissed such allegations. However, there is mounting evidence pointing to the criminal use of bluetooth scanning apps, something that law enforcement officials also attest to. It is recommended not to keep valuables in your car, and even if you have to, it is a good idea to put them all on airplane mode, so that bluetooth scanning apps cannot detect them.

<https://dgit.in/btct>



The \$31 million watch

The record breaking sale of the one of a kind Patek Philippe Grandmaster Chime reference 6300A gives bragging rights to Patek for sure, but also for watch collectors as it means that now watches are being considered on par with luxury cars or pieces of art. <https://dgit.in/31mdw>



The everything town

The story of one small rural town in the middle of nowhere with a single traffic signal, where a number of Amazon processing centers cropped up. Here, the goods are prepared to be shipped, with the particular type of packaging required by Amazon. <https://dgit.in/evrytwn>



Uber to record rides

Uber plans to start recording the audio of rides for its entire duration as a new safety precaution. The idea is to offer enhanced protection to both riders and drivers, and an easy way to settle disputes, allowing the company to easily decide when an action is necessary. <https://dgit.in/ubrado>